INTERVIEW

Mike Mignola

We talk to Mike Mignola about his entry into the comics industry, the creation of Hellboy, adapting comics for the big screen, and how it feels to get to "draw monsters for a living"



Mignola is among the most respected comic authors working today.

What first got you excited about the world of comics?
My cousin was a comic-book reader, and he introduced me to great old Marvel comics – stuff by Stan Lee and Jack Kirby. The bug hit me that there was this whole world, a whole mythology, I was unaware of.

What inspired you to go from being a fan to working in the industry?
From an early age, fuelled by comics and the books I was reading, I loved the supernatural. As I went through art school, my goal was to make a living drawing monsters, but there aren't many jobs doing that! Gearing myself towards becoming an illustrator, I started looking at comics again as a place where I could get away with drawing monsters. I didn't think I was good enough to draw comics, but thought that by getting in there, inking other people's work, I'd eventually get a job drawing covers or something. It never occurred to me to write my own stories at that point.

What exactly prompted you to start scripting then?
After ten years in the business, drawing a lot of stuff that didn't have monsters in it, I realised the only way I was going to get to draw the stuff I wanted to draw was to make it up myself. I co-wrote a Batman story – basically: here's a list of the things I wanna draw – and it was fun. I then thought that instead of making up weird stories and sticking established characters into them, why not make up my own characters, specifically for these kinds of supernatural stories?

And this is when Hellboy was born?
Yeah. I knew the stories and subject matter I wanted to do, and so it was just a matter of making up a character to base stories around. Hellboy isn't a character I'd planned to do; I just wanted a cult detective character. I'd have made him a regular human being, except I knew I'd get bored drawing that, and so I thought of making a fun monster my main character.

***Hellboy* stories contain mythology, horror and fantasy elements. Where does your inspiration for these things come from?**
Well, the first few *Hellboy* books are an explosion – everything and the kitchen sink is thrown in there, because who knew how long I was going to get a chance to do this? So they include everything I ever wanted to draw: pulp magazine horror stories, B-movies, Victorian-era ghost stories... Basically, everything I'd ever seen was the inspiration for the first *Hellboy*!

Later, I gravitated towards folklore – something I've loved since I was a kid. In fact, I'd originally planned on doing straight adaptations of folklore tales, but I realised once I'd done *Hellboy*, and that people liked it, I could do the same stories, but use Hellboy as a device to get people to read them. Straight adaptations of folklore tales would narrow the audience tremendously, but Hellboy, despite being beast of the apocalypse, has an 'everyman' appeal that readers can relate to.

What appeals to you about folklore?
I love the element of the absurd. Stuff happens where you go: "Wow! There's no way I'd have made that up!" You don't know why something works or happens, but the beauty is that it just does. For some reason, someone made up a story where Russian witch Baba Yaga sneaks into a guy's house each night to count his silverware. God knows why! But there's some other logic going on, which I refer to as 'fairy tale logic' – a kind of strangeness I find endlessly fascinating. One of the most important things in supernatural fiction is having an element where we don't understand why things are happening, because once we do, they become science fiction.

And, ironically, you use a demon, Hellboy, to keep the things grounded!
There's a schizophrenic nature to writing *Hellboy*. I listen to a lot of Shakespeare and Bible films, and I have a tendency to write dialogue in that kind of rhythm, especially when dealing with bad guys. After writing a couple of pages of that, I become embarrassed by what I'm doing. Hellboy is the part of me that's my father's son – he'll say, "What the hell are you doing?" and let the reader know that I know the other thing is kind of silly. It's a formula that's worked well. *Hellboy* has my sensibilities, some of my sense of humour, but also my father's real blue-collar working stiff attitude about things.

How did it feel to work on both script and art during *Hellboy*'s early days, thereby having almost total control over your creation?
It's interesting, because initially I never wanted to write this stuff. I enjoyed coming up with stories, but liked the safety net of having a writer who'd put the words in there. John Byrne co-wrote the first *Hellboy* ⇨



The *Hellboy* cartoon has widened the appeal.